MIŻIEN Claim Check 159 · Statistics and international reports

Fifteen times the EU average?

Testing an IMF staff statement on Malta's population density against Eurostat and the World Bank

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

"With a population density fifteen times greater than the EU average …"

International Monetary Fund staff, Country Report No. 26/29, February 2026.
Overview of the 2025 Article IV staff report on Malta.

VERDICT: LARGELY SUPPORTED

The ratio is 16.6 on 2024 data; fifteen is slightly low

Version 1.0 · 9 November 2026
Status: no right of reply needed
Prepared from public sources and open data.
Repository: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien

MIŻIEN · AN INDEPENDENT FACT-CHECKING PROJECT
Contest a verdict, with evidence: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien/issues

TL;DR

In its 2025 Article IV staff report on Malta (Country Report No. 26/29, February 2026), the International Monetary Fund wrote: **“With a population density fifteen times greater than the EU average, straining infrastructure, housing and public services, Malta cannot rely indefinitely on population growth to maintain momentum.”** We tested the density ratio against Eurostat and the World Bank on several definitions of the “EU average”, and the report’s population table against Eurostat.

1. **The ratio is right in substance, and slightly low.** Eurostat gives Malta 1,817 people per km² in 2024 against 110 for the EU-27, a ratio of 16.6. The ratio passed 15 in 2021 (15.1) and has risen every year since.
2. **The answer depends on what “EU average” means.** Against the EU-27 aggregate the ratio is 16.6; against the median of the other 26 states 17.2; against their unweighted mean 13.9. The staff report states no year or definition. Fifteen sits inside the 13.5–17.2 range on every basis we tried.
3. **The population table is close to Eurostat’s, but lower.** IMF 2022 and 2023 values equal Eurostat’s 1 January figures; the 2024 and 2025 values (553,000; 563,000) are about 2% below Eurostat’s (563,443; 574,250), and the 2026 projection (573,000) is 2.6% below Eurostat’s 588,254.
4. **The strain on services is a judgement, not tested here.** The sentence ties density to pressure on infrastructure, housing and services and to a limit on growth. That is the staff’s assessment; it is not a statistic, and we do not rate it.
5. **Verdict: largely supported (high confidence).** The density comparison holds, with a ratio a little above the one stated; the caveats do not change the substance.



16.6×
Malta’s density relative to the EU-27, 2024 (Eurostat)

13.5–17.2×
range across the definitions of “EU average” we tested

1,817
people per km² in Malta, 2024 (total area basis)

–2%
IMF population for 2024–25 against Eurostat 1 January

WHAT WOULD MOVE THE VERDICT UP
Nothing: Supported is the top of the scale. A statement of the year and definition behind “fifteen times” would settle the one caveat but could not raise the verdict.

WHAT WOULD MOVE IT DOWN
A definition of “EU average” under which Malta’s density is well below 13 or above 18 times it, or evidence that the staff compared a different quantity (for example, density of built-up land).

IN THIS REPORT

1 The claim and what we could verify
2 Method
3 What the data show
4 Where the evidence points different ways
5 Testing the claim
6 Verdict and requests for evidence
7 Limitations

1 The claim and what we could verify

The sentence is in the IMF staff's own voice in the Overview of the 2025 Article IV staff report on Malta, published as IMF Country Report No. 26/29 in February 2026 [1]. The Executive Board considered the report on 4 February 2026. We extracted the text of the PDF and read the sentence and the population table on 9 November 2026 (page 8 and Table 1, page 32 of the PDF). The staff give no year, source or definition for the density comparison. Table 1 is sourced to "Authorities' data, Eurostat, and IMF staff estimates and projections".

Source	What it says	Our access	Status
IMF, Country Report 26/29, Feb 2026 [1]	"With a population density fifteen times greater than the EU average, straining infrastructure, housing and public services, Malta cannot rely indefinitely on population growth to maintain momentum." Table 1: population (1,000) 553 (2024), 563 (2025), 573 (2026), 584 (2027).	PDF text read in full for these passages (imf.org refuses scripts; copy fetched through a reader).	**The claim**
Eurostat, demo_r_d3dens [2], demo_gind [3], reg_area3 [4]	National density; population on 1 January; area of each state.	Downloaded 9 Nov 2026 (data/cc-159/).	**Primary data**
World Bank, EN.POP.DNST [5]	People per km² of land area, EU states.	Downloaded 9 Nov 2026.	**Primary data**

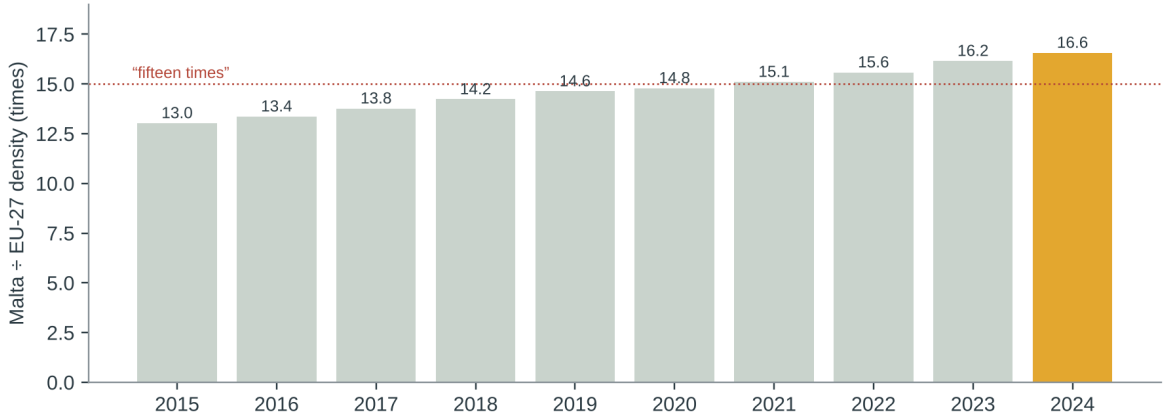
2 Method

Questions. (A) Is Malta's population density about fifteen times the EU average? (B) Is the IMF's population path consistent with the official figures? The sentence's link between density and strain on infrastructure, housing and services is a judgement and is not rated.

Evidence. The ratio was recomputed from Eurostat's national density (people per km² of total area) for Malta and the EU-27 aggregate for 2015–2024; for the EU-27 excluding Malta from population and area; for the median and unweighted mean of the other 26 states; and, as a cross-check on land area, from the World Bank series. The IMF's population values were compared with Eurostat's population on 1 January (*tools/cc-159-report/calc.py*; outputs in *data/cc-159/checks.csv*).

Grades. Official statistics, grade C. No literature is needed to test these figures. **Verdicts** follow the five-point scale in Appendix A.

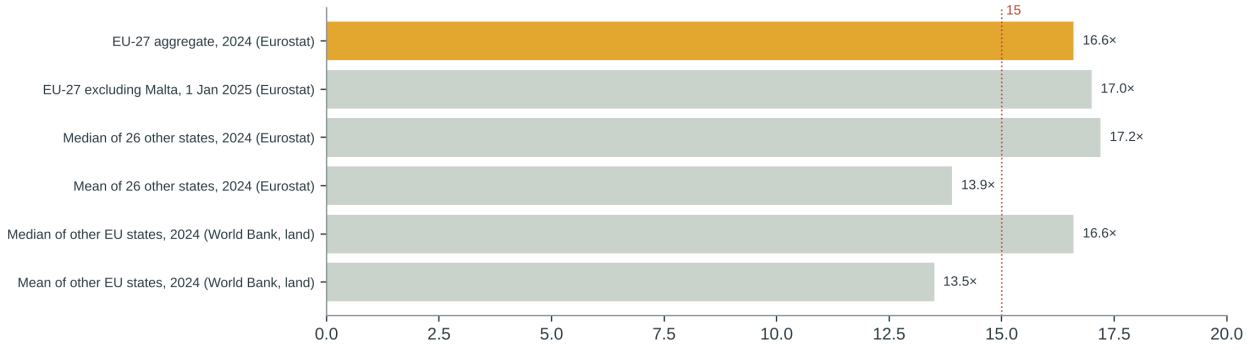
3 What the data show



Source: Eurostat demo_r_d3dens (people per km² of total area; EU-27 aggregate flagged provisional/estimated), retrieved 9 Nov 2026.

Figure 1. Malta's density as a multiple of the EU-27 aggregate, 2015–2024. The ratio crossed fifteen in 2021 and was 16.6 in the latest year.

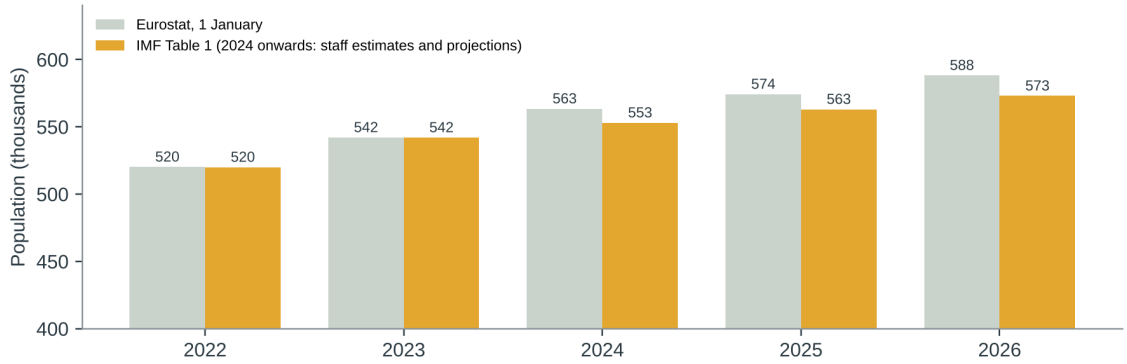
In 2024 Malta had 1,817 people per km² and the EU-27 110 (Eurostat flag: provisional) [2]. Malta is the densest country in the EU by a wide margin: the next, the Netherlands, has 530. Malta's density rose by 29% between 2015 and 2024 while the EU's rose by 1.5%, which is why the ratio keeps climbing; the staff's "fifteen" is the right order and describes roughly 2021–22.



Sources: Eurostat demo_r_d3dens, demo_gind, reg_area3; World Bank EN.POP.DNST; retrieved 9 Nov 2026. Malta ÷ comparator.

Figure 2. Malta's density divided by different versions of "the EU average". The EU-27 aggregate, which weights states by area and population, is the usual meaning of an EU average.

The unweighted mean of national densities is pulled up by a few dense states (the Netherlands, Belgium) and gives a lower ratio, 13.9. The median gives 17.2. The World Bank, which divides by land area, gives similar results (Malta 1,805; 16.6 times the median state; 13.5 times the mean) [5].



Sources: IMF Country Report 26/29, Table 1; Eurostat demo_gind, retrieved 9 Nov 2026. Axis starts at 400.

Figure 3. The IMF's population values (Table 1) and Eurostat's population on 1 January. The IMF's 2022 and 2023 values match Eurostat's; later values are 2–3% lower.

The IMF values for 2022 and 2023 (520,000 and 542,000) equal Eurostat's 1 January figures (520,174 and 542,051) [3]. For 2024 and 2025 the staff figures are staff estimates and projections and are 1.9% and 2.0% below Eurostat's 1 January values; the 2026 value is 2.6% below. We do not know whether the gap reflects timing, a revision, or a different definition of the population. If the IMF's 2025 population is used in the density, the ratio is 16.2 rather than 16.6 (calc.py).

4 Where the evidence points different ways

Is Malta's density "fifteen times" the EU average?

ABOUT RIGHT; LATEST DATA GIVE 16–17

FOR THE CLAIM

On Eurostat's 2024 data Malta's density is 16.6 times the EU-27's, and on the 2021 data 15.1 times: fifteen is within the range of defensible figures and is the ratio of the early 2020s [2].

AGAINST

On the latest year the ratio is above sixteen on the aggregate, the median and the EU excluding Malta, so "fifteen" understates it by about a tenth. Against an unweighted mean of national densities it is 13.9, a tenth below fifteen.

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

A rounded "fifteen times" is a fair summary of a ratio between 14 and 17 on every common definition. The report does not say which year it used, so we cannot say which side its figure is closer to.

5 Testing the claim

Sub-claim	Said by	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. Malta's population density is fifteen times the EU average	IMF [1]	16.6× the EU-27 aggregate in 2024 (1,817 vs 110 per km²); 15.1× in 2021; 13.9–17.2× on other definitions of the average. No year or definition stated.	LARGELY ACCURATE
B. Population (Table 1): 553,000 (2024), 563,000 (2025), 573,000 (2026), 584,000 (2027)	IMF [1]	IMF 2022–23 equal Eurostat; 2024 and 2025 are 1.9% and 2.0% below Eurostat's 1 January values, 2026 is 2.6% below. 2027 has no outturn.	CLOSE; SLIGHTLY LOW
C. Density strains infrastructure, housing and services, so Malta cannot rely indefinitely on population growth	IMF [1]	A policy judgement, not a measurement. Not rated.	NOT RATED

6 Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT

LARGELY SUPPORTED

The density comparison holds, at a ratio slightly above the one stated (16.6 on 2024 data). Confidence: high.

Why. Malta's density is between 14 and 17 times the EU average on every common definition, and 16.6 times the EU-27 aggregate in the latest year. "Fifteen times" is a little low for 2024 but matches the ratio in 2021–22, and the staff's population figures follow Eurostat's within about 2–3%. These caveats do not change the substance. **What this verdict does not say.** It does not assess whether density strains infrastructure, housing or public services, or whether the growth model can continue: those are the staff's judgements.

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ From the IMF: the year and the definition of "EU average" behind "fifteen times".
- ☐ From the IMF: the basis of the 2024–2027 population values in Table 1 and why they sit about 2% below Eurostat's.

RIGHT OF REPLY

Not needed for this verdict (maintainer rule of 5 October 2026).

7 Limitations

- The IMF PDF was refused to scripts (HTTP 403) and the Internet Archive was unreachable on 9 November 2026; we read the text through a reader and checked the sentence and table by extracting the PDF locally. The page was not archived by our tool and needs archiving by hand.
- Eurostat divides by total area and the World Bank by land area; the two differ for Malta by about 12 people per km² and do not change the conclusion.
- The Eurostat EU-27 density for 2024 carries the flag 'provisional' (and earlier years 'estimated' or 'break'); Malta's values carry no flag.

- We do not know which year the staff used. The report was written in 2025–26, so 2024 or 2025 data are the likely basis, but that is our inference.

References

[1] International Monetary Fund. Malta: 2025 Article IV Consultation – Press Release and Staff Report, IMF Country Report No. 26/29, February 2026 (PDF read 9 Nov 2026). https://www.imf.org/-/media/files/publications/cr/2026/english/1mltea2026001-source-pdf.pdf

[2] Eurostat. Population density by NUTS 3 region (demo_r_d3dens), national level, updated 25 Feb 2026, retrieved 9 Nov 2026. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/demo_r_d3dens/default/table

[3] Eurostat. Population change – demographic balance (demo_gind), updated 27 Oct 2026, retrieved 9 Nov 2026. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/demo_gind/default/table

[4] Eurostat. Area by NUTS 3 region (reg_area3), updated 22 Jan 2026, retrieved 9 Nov 2026. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/reg_area3/default/table

[5] World Bank. Population density (people per sq. km of land area), EN.POP.DNST, last updated 8 Oct 2026, retrieved 9 Nov 2026. https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/EN.POP.DNST

[6] MiŻien. Calculation script and outputs: tools/cc-159-report/calc.py; data/cc-159/checks.csv.

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate**: evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low**: evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ◆ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline,** with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it,** and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify,** and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** where a check finds a claim Not substantiated, Misleading or Contradicted (or a pledge Not measurable, Off track or Missed), before wider circulation, and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	9 Nov 2026	First issue. Verdict Largely supported (high confidence); no right of reply needed.